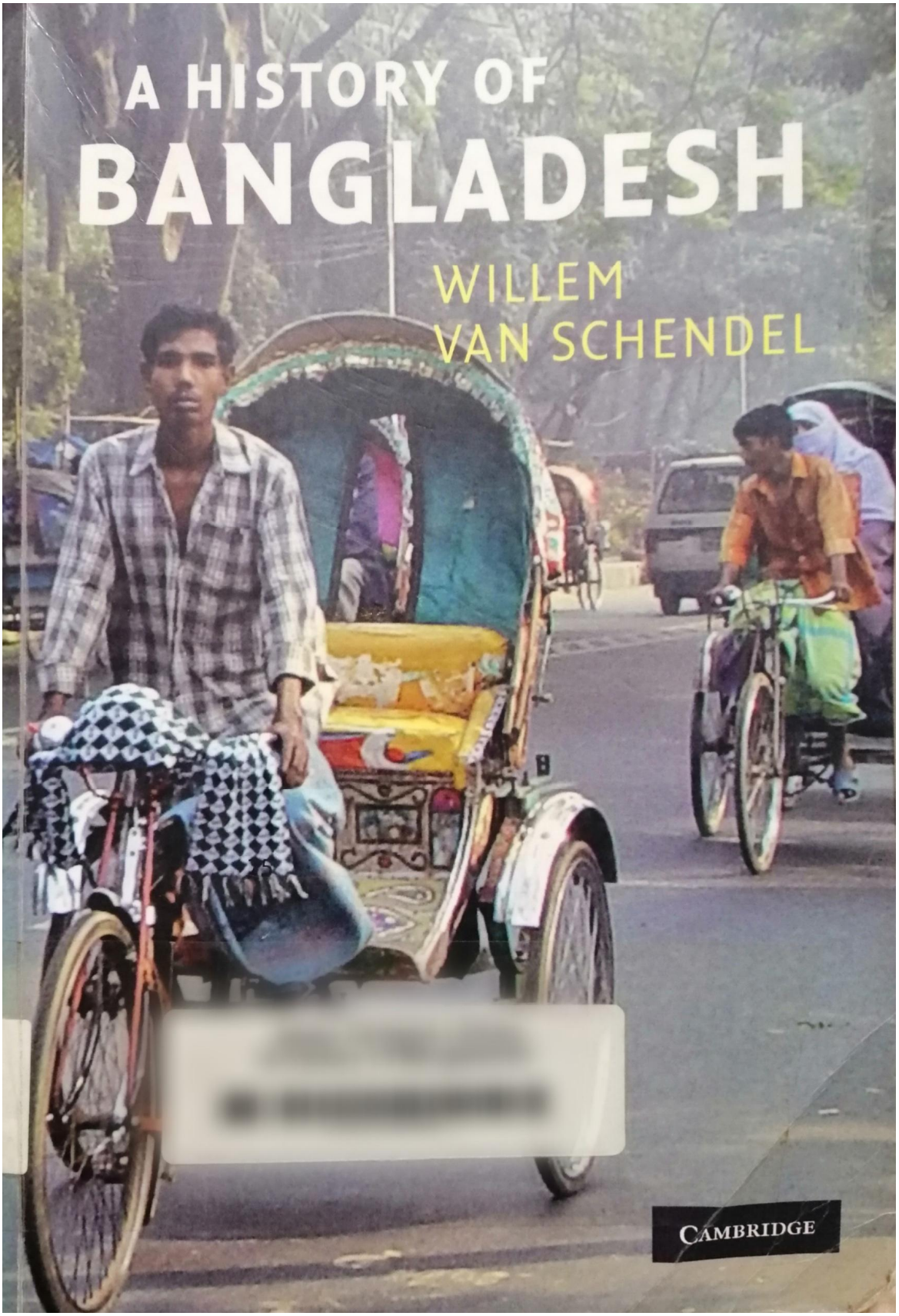

A HISTORY OF
BANGLADESH
WILLEM
VAN SCHENDEL
CAMBRIDGE

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CHAPTER 6

# *The British impact*

The British were unlike the Mughals – they wanted more than just to extract Bengal's riches. It was their ambition to transform Bengal's economy to make it yield them much more income. To this end they combined experiences from Britain and Ireland with South Asian practices, subjecting the population of Bengal to an endless series of administrative and economic experiments. Some of these turned out to be successful, others were disastrous. The early introduction of a system of increased tax collection proved to be calamitous in the uncertain natural conditions of Bengal. It was applied rigidly despite a depletion of people's incomes as a result of drought and then floods in 1769–70. Together with unchecked profiteering in the food-grain markets, this led to intense suffering and an epic famine which is still remembered as the 'Great Famine of 1176' (*chhiyāttarer manbantar**). It is thought that one third of Bengal's population, or a staggering 10 million people, perished. This is how a nineteenth-century researcher described the famine:

> All through the stifling summer of 1770 the people went on dying. The husbandmen sold their cattle; they sold their implements of agriculture; they devoured their seed-grain; they sold their sons and daughters, till at length no buyer of children could be found; they ate the leaves of trees and the grass of the field; and in June, 1770, the Resident at the Durbar affirmed that the living were feeding on the dead. Day and night a torrent of famished and disease-stricken wretches poured into the great cities. At an early period of the year pestilence had broken out. In March we find small-pox at Moorshedabad [Murshidabad] . . . The streets were blocked up with promiscuous heaps of the dying and dead. Interment could not do its work quick enough; even the dogs and jackals, the public scavengers of the East, became unable to accomplish

* The Bengali calendar differs from the Common Era calendar (CE) in its starting point. It has solar years and each year begins in mid-April. Thus the year 2000 CE equals the year 1406/7 BE (= Bengali Era) and the Great Famine of 1176 refers to the year 1769/70. See Van Schendel, 'Modern Times in Bangladesh', for details.

their revolting work, and the multitude of mangled and festering corpses at length threatened the existence of the citizens . . . In 1770, the rainy season brought relief, and before the end of September the province reaped an abundant harvest. But the relief came too late to avert depopulation. Starving and shelterless crowds crawled despairingly from one deserted village to another in a vain search for food, or a resting-place in which to hide themselves from the rain. The epidemics incident to the season were thus spread over the whole country; and, until the close of the year, disease continued so prevalent as to form a subject of communication from the government in Bengal to the Court of Directors [in London]. Millions of famished wretches died in the struggle to live through the few intervening weeks that separated them from the harvest, their last gaze being probably fixed on the densely-covered fields that would ripen only a little too late for them.[1]

This unconscionable debacle forced the British overlords to find more sustainable ways of exploiting the resources of their new colony. They developed policies that shaped a new colonial society. Historians of Bengal, who have concentrated their studies mostly on the colonial period, have provided us with a richly textured and enormously detailed understanding of the complex social and economic permutations of Bengal under British rule between 1757 and 1947.[2] Here we highlight only a few major effects of special significance for the emergence of post-colonial Bangladesh.

## THE PERMANENT SETTLEMENT

The most momentous decision of the early colonial period was the creation of a new system of land taxation which came to be known as the 'permanent settlement'.[3] Introduced in 1790 and codified in 1793, it was important because it was more than merely a tax system. It formed the nucleus of the colonial system of control; other parts of the administration such as the executive, the judiciary and the police were geared to the desired working of the permanent settlement.[4] It survived with modifications till the 1950s and moulded social and economic relations in the delta to such an extent that contemporary Bangladesh society cannot be understood without reference to it.

The permanent settlement was a deal that the British struck with the tax-collecting rural gentry, the zamindars. The British (who arrogated the ultimate property rights of all land in Bengal) made the zamindars the *de facto* landowners and fixed the tax demand in perpetuity: the state would not enhance the rate in future. In return, the zamindars were bound to pay their taxes with clockwork punctuality on pain of their land being

auctioned off. In this way, zamindari control of local society was harnessed to the colonial state and zamindars became the mainstay of colonial control and extraction. At the same time their power was circumscribed by the threat of expropriation in case of arrears in tax payments to the state.

The expectation behind the permanent settlement was that, over time, zamindars would become improving landlords who would invest in agricultural development. Fixed government taxes, rising produce prices and new land under the plough would leave more and more wealth in the zamindars' hands. By reinvesting in agriculture, they would boost the delta's economy. This did not happen, however, partly because zamindars lacked government support for agricultural development, better communications, technological innovation and control of marketing, and partly because there were easier ways to grow rich. Popular strategies included squeezing the peasantry by (illegally) increasing rents and forcing tenants to pay contributions to events in the zamindar's family such as marriages, festivals, pilgrimages and funerals.

As their incomes grew, zamindars began to distance themselves from agriculture and tax-collecting. They turned themselves into rentiers and shifted their responsibilities to intermediaries. Bengal's peasants produced so much wealth that these intermediaries were often able to follow the zamindars' example by appointing their own intermediaries. In this way, a multitiered system of leisured tenure-holders developed, all living off the wealth of the land. This system, known as sub-infeudation or pottonidari (*pattanidāri*), was most developed in what is now southern Bangladesh. For example, in the district of Barisal you had to cut through five to seven layers of intermediate tenures to get to the tiller of the soil.[5] In this way, the permanent settlement encouraged the development of a very hierarchical social structure dominated by an extensive leisured class.

There was another reason why the permanent settlement was a system with momentous consequences: it denied the peasantry any property rights in land. Previously there had been complex and locally variable bundles of property rights vested in both peasant producers and landlords. Now these rights were granted only to the landlords who could freely sell, mortgage or gift their land. In the eyes of the law, cultivators became mere tenants with a right to work the land – if they paid their rent regularly – but they could transfer this 'occupancy right' only by inheritance, not by sale. Not all tenants acquired this occupancy right and over time a growing proportion of cultivators were mere tenants-at-will whom the landlord could eject at any time. In this way colonial rural

Bengal came to be dominated by zamindari land owners whose land was tilled by tenants with occupancy rights – in which case they were known as *rāiyat* – or without such rights. The zamindari gentry benefited enormously from the colonial state's patronage. Many of them grew very rich indeed and built palatial mansions on their estates (Plate 6.1; and see box 'First-rate art in a country town').

At the same time the composition of the zamindari gentry changed. Whereas Muslims had dominated during the reclamation of the eastern delta in the Mughal period, the colonial period saw an advance of Hindu landlords. Although neither Muslim zamindars nor Hindu tenants were rare by any means, in many parts of the eastern delta religious and class identities began to merge, with Hindu zamindars at the apex of a local society consisting largely of Muslim cultivators. In the western delta Hindu zamindars dominated as well but here the majority of the cultivators were also Hindus. This regional difference had no political ramifications in the early colonial period but it would become a highly salient political question towards its end.

## CROPS FOR FAR-FLUNG MARKETS

A second major change in the colonial period was the introduction of large-scale export-oriented cash cropping. Previously Bengal's agriculture had been considerably commercialised, producing cotton, rice, sugarcane, mulberry, betel nut and many other crops for various markets. These crops were processed in Bengal and often exported. In other words, commercial crop production was nothing new. What set the colonial period apart, however, was the organisation of cash cropping, the scale of its production and a succession of new crops that began to be produced for overseas markets. European and South Asian capital was invested in the large-scale production of opium, indigo, tea, silk and jute. Some of these crops were grown under systems of coerced labour, others on plantations – capitalist agricultural enterprises run by Europeans – and yet others by indebted smallholders (Plate 6.3).

Colonial cash cropping was important because it forged new ties between Bengal's rural economy and European and Asian markets. British imperial expansion, in South Asia as well as elsewhere in the continent, was buttressed by the wealth generated in Bengal, and at the same time cash cropping had a number of fundamental effects on the delta's society. It also led to a new regional specialisation of the Bengal economy: eastern Bangladesh became the heartland of jute

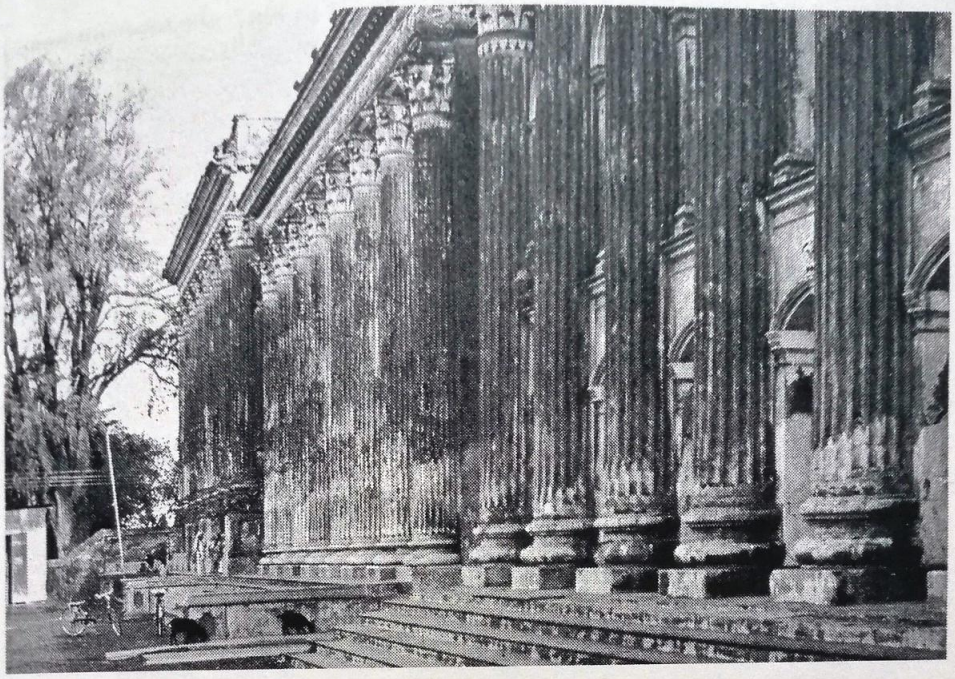
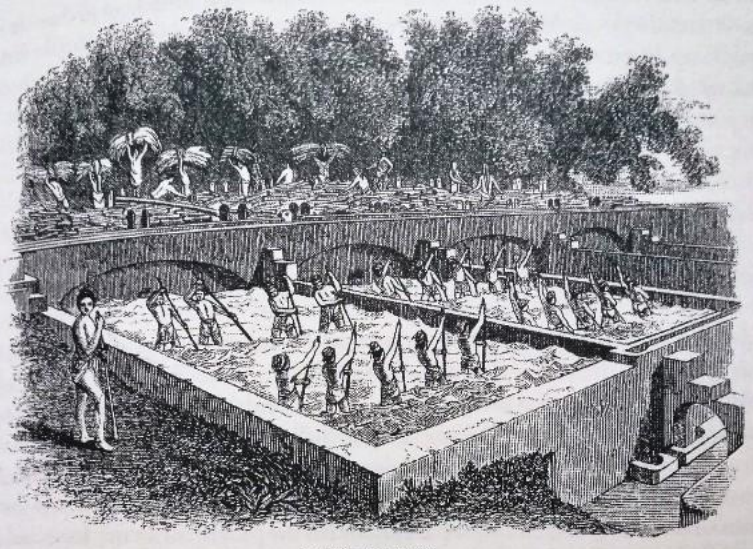


Plate 6.1. Remains of a zamindari mansion in central Bangladesh (Baliati *rājbāṛi*, Manikganj district).[6]

**First-rate art in a country town**

In contemporary Bangladesh the zamindari landlords are remembered mainly as a bossy and parasitic gentry. Their grandiose lifestyle was based on the exploitation of peasant labour, and it is true that most of them gave little in return. There were exceptions, however: landlords who set up rural schools, libraries and clinics, improved the infrastructure of their estates, donated water supply systems or provided their tenants with support in times of scarcity.

One priceless inheritance of zamindari initiative is the Varendra Research Museum in Rajshahi, a town in western Bangladesh. It is Bangladesh's oldest museum, established in 1910 by a group of aristocratic history buffs who wanted to promote the study of North Bengal. They gave their museum the ancient name for this region – the term also survives in 'Barind', the modern name for much of northern Bangladesh. The initiators of the Varendra museum undertook numerous trips around the region to gather objects of antiquarian value, and they even sponsored and organised archaeological digs. Soon the museum was filling up with an outstanding collection from different historical periods.



BEATING THE INDIGO

Plate 6.3. Producing indigo, a blue dyestuff, for export to Europe.

production; sugar and silk were concentrated in western Bangladesh and tobacco in the north. Particular forms of social organisation and land control were associated with these crops.[8] In eastern Bangladesh peasant smallholders were faced with dwindling holdings resulting from population growth and partible inheritance. Unable to feed their families with subsistence crops alone, they were forced into market production. The regional economy became highly monetised as foreign funds flowed in to finance agrarian exports – mainly jute – and credit-dependent peasant producers were fully exposed to international market uncertainties. By contrast, in northern and western Bangladesh rural elites were major providers of agrarian credit, often in the form of rice loans to sharecroppers, and this shielded the primary producers from the direct effects of market forces.[9]

Both regional systems were affected by the world economic crisis of the 1930s. Eastern Bangladesh was particularly hard hit because the market for jute collapsed, credit dried up and it was impossible to return to the subsistence agriculture of the nineteenth century for lack of sufficient

land. Old relations of social and political control broke down, giving way to increasingly violent conflicts between peasants and the regional elite made up of moneylenders, traders and landlords. In northern and western Bangladesh, the crisis initially intensified sharecroppers' and labourers' dependence on the grain-lending elite, but when land and crop prices began to recover a decade later, sharecroppers began to demand better conditions, culminating in widespread agitations in the closing years of British rule.

## NEW INSTITUTIONS OF RULE

Mughal rule had brought important administrative innovations to the Bengal delta. British rule introduced further major changes, some of which had long-lasting effects. New ideas about law and property rights were translated into novel judicial institutions. By the 1830s the British dropped Persian – the Mughal language of rule – as the state's official language. English-language schools and colleges trained a small proportion of the Bengali elite to prepare them for employment at the lower and middle levels of the colonial system. Two modern universities were set up in Kolkata (1857) and Dhaka (1921) and quickly established excellent academic reputations. A third field of institutional change was health. Demographic growth during the British period owed much to the fact that people knew more about hygiene and had better access to medicines and hospitals. Roads, bridges and railways made transport in the Bengal delta less dependent on waterways, and other technological advances such as the telegraph, telephone and radio made it easier to spread information. The span of state control improved as the police and army became better funded and organised. Although the state remained firmly authoritarian, political pressure made it necessary for the British to experiment gingerly with restricted forms of popular representation in the closing decades of their rule. The colonial framework proved long-lived: despite turbulent state formation since British times, it remains clearly visible in Bangladesh's judicial, educational, health, engineering and military institutions today.

## THE RISE OF KOLKATA

A final major change during the colonial period was the emergence of Calcutta (now Kolkata) as the new centre of political power and cultural renewal. The city, established by the British in 1690, became the capital of

colonial Bengal and, as British power expanded, also the capital of all of colonial India. This is where the government of India resided from 1757 to 1931. Up to the mid-nineteenth century this government was headed by successive governors-general who were appointed by the directors of the British East India Company. From 1858 the British monarch appointed the head of the government of India, now styled the Viceroy of India. Kolkata was the nerve-centre of the colonial administration and it developed rapidly. Ambitious Bengalis of all kinds soon flocked to the city; among them the scions of wealthy families with landed estates, often in the eastern delta, set the cultural tone. Many soon acquired an English education and took up professions or positions in the colonial state. Historians later labelled this group, in which upper-caste Hindus predominated, the 'bhodrolok' (*bhadralok*; gentlefolk).[10] They became pre-eminent cultural brokers between the population of Bengal and their British overlords, not just in Kolkata but also in the provincial towns and zamindari mansions of the east Bengal countryside.[11] Throughout Bengal, many sought to emulate the distinct and refined Kolkata-orientated bhodrolok lifestyle, but in eastern Bengal, where it was closely associated with (absentee) landlordism, elitism and caste-ism, this lifestyle was also deeply resented.

Colonial Kolkata was more than Bengal's prime administrative and cultural city. It also emerged as its commercial and economic hub. Valuable cash crops such as opium (for the Chinese market) and indigo and tea (for the European market) were transhipped in its port, and jute from the fields of eastern Bengal was processed in its many jute factories before being exported. From the 1850s a network of railway lines began to radiate from Kolkata to speed up the transport of goods from the hinterland. At the same time, however, many industrial centres in eastern Bengal declined or stagnated. The most dramatic example was Dhaka, which, till the early eighteenth century, had been the capital of Bengal and, till the British take-over, a major textile-exporting city. By 1800, however, British commercial policies and the rise of Kolkata had led to a sharp decline.[12] Dhaka's exports of fine textiles had halved and would soon disappear; its population had shrunk to about 200,000 and would dwindle to about 50,000 in the 1840s, Dhaka's lowest point (Plate 6.4).[13] After that Dhaka began to recover gradually, mainly as a result of the jute trade and administrative expansion, but it did not recover the population level of 1800 till the 1930s and did not regain its industrial prowess till the 1970s.